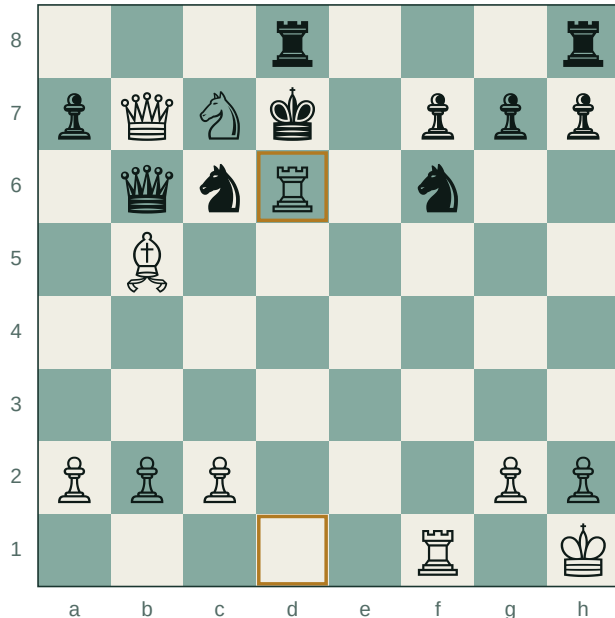


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 19

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 19.Rxd6+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19...Kxd6 20. Qxb6 axb6

19...Kxd6 The king captures the rook on d6. Recorded reply: **20.Qxb6**.

20...axb6 The pawn captures the queen on b6.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +5:** the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: queen on b7 and rook on d6. Check for tactical protection.